

VISUAL REBUS APP

Market, Product and Launch Plan

A short, practical build plan for a mobile-first app created in VS Code

PICTURES

WORDS

AHA!

Decision in one sentence

Build a polished, original visual-puzzle MVP quickly - but compete on fairness, explanations and trust, not merely prettier colours.

Target: playable prototype in 48 hours | **Launch-ready MVP: 5-7 focused workdays** | **Public Android launch may require 14+ testing days**

Prepared for VS Code workflow | No code included | Research current to 15 July 2026

1. Executive decision

GO - with a narrow scope

The market is proven but not empty. Dingbats has strong historical traction, while newer apps already offer colour, pictures, daily puzzles and multiplayer. Your opportunity is a faster, cleaner and more trustworthy product with better clue design and explanations.

What the evidence says

- Demand exists: Dingbats shows 1M+ Google Play downloads and tens of thousands of reviews.[1]
- Competition is active: Mister Rebus shows 100K+ downloads; Rebus Puzzles shows 10K+; RapidRebus launched a feature-heavy product with 1,000+ claimed handcrafted puzzles.[3][4][6]
- Quality alone is not distribution: RapidRebus lists only 100+ Google Play downloads and one App Store rating despite a strong feature set.[6]
- The largest visible gap is not “add pictures.” Several competitors already use images, symbols, colour, daily content, streaks and social play.[3][4][5][6]
- The practical gap is fair puzzle design, useful progressive clues, accepted answer variants, clear explanations, transparent monetisation and a lightweight mobile experience.

Do not mistake a quick build for a quick public launch

- A working web prototype can be built in two focused days.
- A launch-quality mobile app needs original content, QA, store assets, privacy declarations, purchase restoration and device testing.
- For newer Google Play personal accounts, production access requires a closed test with at least 12 continuously opted-in testers for 14 days before applying.[10]

Market snapshot

Competitor	Visible traction	Strength	Weakness/opportunity
Dingbats - Between the lines	1M+ Android downloads; 4.6; 28.7K reviews	Large library, regular updates, mixed puzzle modes	Dated/mixed presentation; regional phrase friction; hint complaints; complex IAP menu
Mister Rebus	100K+ Android downloads	Colourful puzzles, offline, coin hints	Basic value proposition; tracking/ads; little visible differentiation beyond colour
Rebus Puzzles - Brain Teasers	10K+ Android downloads	Hundreds, four difficulty levels, hints	Generic feature set; weak social/daily/explanation story
Rebus Quest	Too few AU App Store ratings for overview	Picture riddles, packs, XP, daily goals, polished progression	Large app size; early traction; still no obvious explanation-first advantage
RapidRebus	100+ Android downloads; 1 iOS rating	1,000+ claimed puzzles, daily, multiplayer, leaderboards, offline	Strongest direct benchmark; low visible traction means discovery remains hard
Riddles, Rebuses and Two Pics	Low App Store review volume	400 mixed puzzles; only 100 rebus puzzles	Diluted identity; mixed game types; older presentation

2. Weaknesses to exploit

Weakness	Evidence	Your counter-move
Unfair or obscure answers	Dingbats acknowledges regional sayings, and reviews complain about unfamiliar phrases and depictions that remain unclear even after solving. [1][2]	Use a global-common core pack. Label regional packs. Show the reasoning after every solve.
Poor hint value	A review reports random letter hints can reveal letters already entered correctly. [2]	Build a clue ladder: concept clue -> visual clue -> targeted letter -> answer reveal. Never charge twice for known information.
Repetitive experience	An App Store review calls the loop tedious after only a few levels. [2]	Rotate puzzle formats: typography, icons, photos/illustrations, motion, sound and interaction.
Monetisation distrust	Dingbats lists several separate no-ad price options and multiple hint packs; the user also experienced bonus content that still prompted ads. [2]	One clear purchase. State exactly what it removes. Ad-free users receive non-ad ways to earn hints.
Progress and purchase risk	A July 2026 Google Play review reports lost progress and a vanished no-ads payment. [1]	Local autosave, cloud backup only later, and a visible Restore Purchases button from launch.
Weak explanation layer	Most listings focus on solving, hints and coins rather than teaching why each clue works.	Make the explanation screen a core reward, not an afterthought.
Privacy and accessibility gaps	Dingbats and Mister Rebus disclose advertising/tracking data; Dingbats has not declared Apple accessibility support. [2][4]	Minimise SDKs. Avoid account creation. Support larger text, high contrast, screen-reader labels and reduced motion.
Generic store positioning	Many listings repeat "brain training," "hundreds of puzzles," and "think outside the box." [3][4][5]	Own a sharper promise: "Fair visual riddles with clues that help and explanations that make sense."

What not to copy

- Do not copy the Dingbats name, icon, screenshots, exact UI, source code or puzzle collection.
- Do not submit a minor reskin. Apple warns copycat apps may fail review, and Google rejects apps that merely repeat an existing experience. [8][9]
- Use common public-domain phrases only as answer concepts, then create your own layouts, artwork, clues and explanations.
- Keep a simple originality log for every puzzle: creator, date, source phrase, visual concept and tester notes.

3. Product position and audience

Working product promise

“Quick visual riddles that feel clever, never cheap. Get useful clues, understand the answer, and challenge a friend.”

Primary audience

- Casual mobile puzzle players who want 2-5 minute sessions during commutes, breaks or evenings.
- English-speaking adults in Australia, New Zealand, the United Kingdom, the United States and Canada.
- People who enjoy Wordle, trivia, picture riddles, lateral-thinking puzzles and family challenge games.
- Launch with behaviour-based targeting rather than assuming a narrow gender demographic.

Secondary audience

- Older players seeking low-pressure brain exercise with readable text and offline play.
- Families, partners and friendship groups who solve together.
- Teachers and language learners using idioms and visual meaning - later, after the core game is proven.

Content policy for regions

- Core pack: internationally common phrases only.
- Optional packs: Australian sayings, British sayings, American sayings, movies, music, sports and workplace phrases.
- Every regional or culturally specific puzzle must be labelled before the player spends a hint.
- Accept spelling variants where appropriate: colour/color, centre/center, grey/gray.

Launch content quantity

Item	Target	Reason
Playable launch library	120 puzzles	Enough for 20-40 short sessions without creating months of content first.
Reserve / daily queue	30 puzzles	Lets you publish daily content while building the next batch.
Easy	40	Teach the visual language; high confidence; common phrases.
Medium	50	Combine two clue mechanisms.
Hard	30	Multiple mechanisms, but still fair after clues.
Puzzle formats	At least 6	Typography, symbol/icon, illustrated object, mixed text-image, motion, interactive arrangement.
Minimum testers per puzzle	3 people	At least one tester should not know the intended answer beforehand.

Content rule

A 150-puzzle plan is better than advertising “1,000 puzzles” filled with weak or ambiguous material. Add volume only after completion data proves quality.

4. Feature plan: build now, later, never

MVP must-haves

#	Feature	Definition of done
1	Puzzle display engine	Render text, images, icons, position, colour, scale and simple motion from puzzle data.
2	Answer entry	Show word lengths; ignore case/punctuation; support accepted variants and near-miss feedback.
3	Progressive clue ladder	Three useful clues plus optional reveal. Never reveal a letter already correctly placed.
4	Explanation screen	Explain each visual element step by step after solve or reveal.
5	Progress and packs	Easy/Medium/Hard, completion percentage and continue button.
6	Daily puzzle	One shared daily challenge, streak and share card without showing the answer.
7	Offline-first save	Local progress, settings and unlocked content; no login required.
8	Fair monetisation	Optional rewarded hint ads; one genuine ad-free purchase; restore purchases.
9	Puzzle feedback	Buttons for "fair," "confusing," "wrong answer," and "report a bug."
10	Accessibility/settings	Large text, high contrast, reduced motion, sound/haptics toggles and screen-reader labels.
11	Basic analytics	Puzzle start, solve, fail, clue usage, abandon, purchase and crash events - no invasive profiling.
12	Store/privacy basics	Privacy policy, data declarations, age rating, support email and unique store assets.

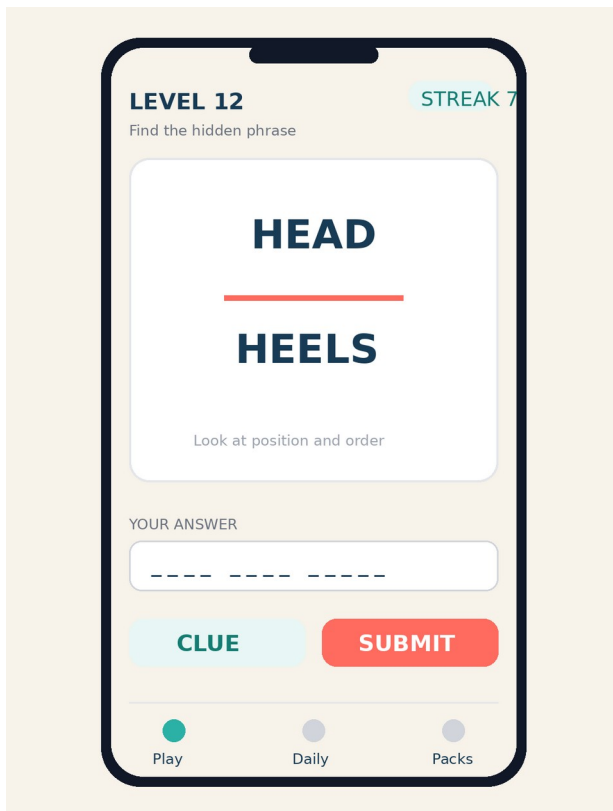
Defer until retention is proven

- Accounts, cloud sync and cross-device profiles.
- Real-time multiplayer, global leaderboards and chat.
- User-generated puzzles and moderation systems.
- Live AI clue generation. Use reviewed static clues first.
- Subscriptions. Start with one-time purchases and optional ads.
- Multiple game types such as anagrams and unrelated riddles.

Recommended monetisation rules

- First 10 puzzles: no forced ad.
- Rewarded video: optional, used for an extra clue or skip.
- Interstitials: preferably none at launch; if tested later, cap at one after 6-8 completed puzzles, never after a failed guess.
- Ad-free/supporter purchase: one clearly described product, approximately A\$4.99-A\$7.99 to test.
- Ad-free users: receive daily clue credits instead of being asked to watch ads.
- No locked "bonus game" that contradicts the meaning of "remove ads."

5. Visual direction and GUI specification



Design theme: modern editorial puzzle card

Mood: Warm, clever, calm and premium - not casino-like, childish or cluttered.

Puzzle focus: One central high-contrast card using roughly two-thirds of the screen.

Navigation: Thumb-friendly bottom actions. Keep coins, streaks and menus visually secondary.

Typography: Manrope or Space Grotesk for headings; Inter/system font for body and answer input.

Motion: Fast 150-250 ms transitions. Celebrate briefly. Respect reduced-motion settings.

Touch targets: Minimum 44 x 44 points; large answer and clue controls.

Illustration: Consistent flat/vector style with a limited palette. Avoid random stock-art mixtures.

Suggested palette

Ink #183B56	Teal #2CB1A6	Coral #FF6B5F	Warm paper #F7F3EA	Gold #F2C94C
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Required screens

- Onboarding: one example puzzle, one clue demonstration, then immediate play.
- Home: Continue, Daily Puzzle, packs, progress. No busy dashboard.
- Puzzle: central clue, answer blanks, clue, submit and report controls.
- Solved: answer, animated explanation, next puzzle, share challenge.
- Pack screen: difficulty, completion, locked/unlocked status and clear price labels.
- Settings: purchases, restore, privacy, accessibility, sound, haptics and support.

6. Puzzle production system

Every puzzle must contain

Field	Instruction
ID	Unique stable number
Answer	Canonical phrase
Accepted answers	Spelling, punctuation and regional variants
Word pattern	Example: 4-6-3
Difficulty	Easy / Medium / Hard
Format	Text, icon, illustration, photo, motion, interaction
Visual specification	Exact positions, sizes, rotations, colours and assets
Clue 1	Broad concept without answer words
Clue 2	Directs attention to the visual mechanism
Clue 3	Targeted word/letter help
Explanation	One to three short steps showing why it works
Region	Global / AU / UK / US / other
Originality log	Creator, date and source phrase
QA status	Draft / tested / approved / rejected

Six launch formats

1. Typography placement: words above, below, inside, split, repeated or reversed.
2. Text plus icon: combine a word with one or more simple symbols.
3. Illustrated object placement: objects inside, behind, around or crossing another object.
4. Scale/colour/rotation: size, colour or orientation carries meaning.
5. Motion: falling, running, fading, looping or crossing the screen.
6. Interactive: drag one object into position or tap the unusual element.

Puzzle approval gate

- At least 2 of 3 blind testers solve it without the final clue.
- All testers understand the explanation immediately after reveal.
- No answer depends on a phrase unknown to the labelled region.
- No two materially different phrases fit equally well.
- Accepted spellings and punctuation are recorded.
- Artwork and layout are original or properly licensed.
- Reject weak puzzles. Do not keep them merely to increase the count.

7. VS Code project workflow and time plan

Recommended technical direction

Build mobile-first HTML/CSS/JavaScript, store puzzle content as data, and package the same project for Android/iOS with Capacitor. This matches your existing skills and keeps the web prototype usable.

Folder structure

```
visual-rebus-app/
  README_START_HERE.md
  docs/                research, UX rules, launch checklists
  assets/brand/         icon, logo, palette, fonts/licences
  assets/puzzles/       illustrations, icons, animations
  data/                puzzle library and daily schedule
  src/                 app screens and logic
  store/               screenshots, descriptions, privacy links
  testing/             tester list, device matrix, bug log
```

Hands-on work estimate

Step	Time	Completion
0. Decide scope and name criteria	2-3 h	Product promise, audience, formats, monetisation rules, app-name shortlist.
1. UX flow and visual system	4-6 h	Wireframe six screens, palette, type, spacing and interaction rules.
2. Project shell and navigation	3-5 h	Mobile layout, screen routing, local storage and settings shell.
3. Core puzzle and answer engine	8-12 h	Render puzzle data, validate answers, variants, word lengths and progression.
4. Six visual puzzle formats	8-14 h	Text, icon, image, scale/rotation, motion and simple interaction.
5. Clues, explanations and daily mode	6-10 h	Clue ladder, solved animation, daily seed, streak and share result.
6. Create and test 150 puzzles	15-30 h	Largest variable. Build 120 playable plus 30 reserve; test and reject weak items.
7. Monetisation and analytics	6-10 h	Ads, one-time purchase, restore, consent, events and crash reporting.
8. Accessibility and QA	8-14 h	Device testing, offline, text size, rotation, purchase paths and error states.
9. Store and legal package	6-9 h	Icon, screenshots, description, privacy policy, data safety and age rating.
10. Closed beta and fixes	4-8 h hands-on	Recruit testers, review feedback and fix launch blockers.

Realistic total

Playable prototype: 12-18 hours. Good MVP test build: 45-65 hours. Launch-quality 150-puzzle version: roughly 70-110 hours, mostly content and QA.

8. Seven-day execution plan

Day	Work	Exit result
Day 1	Lock scope; create folder; design Home, Puzzle and Solved screens; build 10 sample puzzle specs.	A clickable visual shell and final design rules.
Day 2	Build answer handling, word patterns, progress saving and next-puzzle flow.	25 text-based puzzles fully playable.
Day 3	Add image/icon, scale/rotation, motion and interaction formats.	Six supported puzzle formats.
Day 4	Add clue ladder, explanations, accepted variants, daily mode and share card.	Core differentiators complete.
Day 5	Create/import remaining content; test with three people; reject ambiguous puzzles.	120 playable + 30 reserve.
Day 6	Add settings, accessibility, monetisation, restore purchase, analytics and privacy pages.	Monetisable beta build.
Day 7	Device QA, store screenshots, description, closed test setup and bug fixes.	Release candidate submitted to testing.

48-hour version - only if speed is the priority

- Web/PWA only, 25 polished puzzles, three formats, local progress, clues and explanations.
- No ads, purchases, accounts, daily mode, multiplayer or store submission.
- Use it to validate whether strangers enjoy the product before completing the mobile package.

Public launch timing

- Existing eligible Play account: submit after QA; review timing is outside your control.
- Newer personal Play account: plan at least 14 continuous closed-testing days with 12 testers, then production-access review.[10]
- Use the test period to publish social puzzle content, gather emails and improve the next 50 puzzles.
- Consider launching the web version while the mobile store process runs.

9. Audience acquisition and launch marketing

Core message

Do not advertise “another dingbat app.”

Advertise the experience: “Can you solve this visual phrase in 10 seconds?” The puzzle itself is the marketing creative.

Store positioning

- Title/subtitle should include a distinctive brand plus descriptive terms such as visual riddles, picture puzzles or rebus game.
- Keywords to test: rebus puzzles, picture riddles, brain teasers, visual word game, word puzzles, lateral thinking, daily puzzle.
- First screenshot: a genuinely solvable puzzle with the challenge “Can you get it in 10 seconds?”
- Second screenshot: the clue ladder. Third: the satisfying explanation. Fourth: daily/share challenge.
- Do not use another app’s branding or make unsupported “#1” claims.

Organic content plan

Channel	Execution	Launch target
Daily short video	Show one puzzle for 5-8 seconds, timer, reaction, then app name. Do not reveal immediately.	7 per week
Street/family challenge	Offer a small prize for solving three puzzles; film with permission; focus on reactions.	1 per week
Comment bait without deception	“What answer did you get?” “Which clue gave it away?”	Every post
Share card	Solved time, streak and puzzle link; no answer shown.	Built into app
Micro-influencers	Puzzle, trivia, family, teacher and brain-game accounts with small but engaged audiences.	Contact 20; test 3-5
Community testing	Puzzle groups, local friends, workmates and family; ask for fairness ratings, not praise.	12+ testers

Paid promotion rule

- Do not spend heavily before Day-7 retention and monetisation are known.
- Start with small creator payments or prize-based challenge videos rather than broad Facebook ads.
- Reuse the best organic video as the first paid creative.
- Stop any campaign where the cost per retained player is clearly higher than expected lifetime revenue.

10. Launch gates and success metrics

Do not submit until

- [] No crash in a full 30-puzzle session on at least three Android devices/screen sizes.
- [] Progress survives close/reopen, update and offline use.
- [] Purchases restore correctly; ad-free behaviour matches the product description.
- [] Every launch puzzle has three clues, accepted variants and an explanation.
- [] No placeholder text, broken letters, clipped images or unreadable dark-mode screens.
- [] Privacy policy and store data declarations match every SDK used.[11][12]
- [] App has unique content and presentation sufficient to avoid copycat/repetitive-content concerns.[8][9]
- [] Support email, report button and version number are visible.
- [] Twelve testers are recruited early if the Play account is subject to the closed-test rule.[10]

Metrics to watch

Metric	Initial target	Action
Tutorial completion	80%+	If low: onboarding is too long or confusing.
First-session puzzles solved	5+ median	If low: difficulty or answer input is frustrating.
Day-1 return	Aim 30%+ for early test	Directionally useful; compare versions, not only benchmarks.
Day-7 return	Aim 10-15%+ initially	If weak: daily loop and content quality need work.
Clue usage	Track by puzzle	High usage on one puzzle indicates ambiguity or bad difficulty.
Reveal after clues	Low and declining	High rate means clues do not teach effectively.
Fair/confusing rating	85% fair	Remove or rewrite low-scoring puzzles.
Ad-free conversion	Observe, do not force	Use pricing tests only after trust is established.
Share rate	1-3%+ of solved sessions	A key signal for organic growth.

Decision after 30 days

Continue only if players return and rate puzzles as fair. A prettier app with poor retention is not a business; a small app with strong repeat play is worth expanding.

11. Exact next actions

1. Open the supplied project folder in VS Code and read README_START_HERE.md.
2. Choose a temporary working name. Do not spend more than 30 minutes naming it today.
3. Confirm whether your Google Play developer account is existing or a newer personal account subject to closed testing.
4. Create 10 excellent puzzle specifications across at least four formats before building the renderer.
5. Build only Home -> Puzzle -> Solved -> Next first.
6. Use the 10 puzzles to test answer variants, clues and explanations.
7. Recruit 12 testers immediately, even before the app is finished.
8. Complete the 48-hour prototype before adding ads, coins or accounts.
9. At 25 puzzles, let strangers test it and record every confusing answer.
10. Proceed to the seven-day MVP only if the core loop creates genuine “aha” reactions.

Recommended starting scope

Start with a high-quality 25-puzzle prototype. The fastest route to a good 150-puzzle app is to prove the data structure and quality rules on 25 puzzles first.

Project folder deliverables

- This PDF market and build plan.
- README_START_HERE.md with the exact order of work.
- Build checklist, puzzle content specification, launch checklist and research notes.
- Empty folders for assets, data, source files, store assets and testing records.
- No application code has been added.

Sources and research notes

Store counts, ratings and product features can change. Figures below are a snapshot accessed on 15 July 2026. User-review excerpts were used as directional evidence, not as proof that every user has the same experience.

1. Google Play - Dingbats - Between the lines - <https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=aasuted.net.word>
2. Apple App Store - Dingbats - Between the lines, reviews, privacy and in-app purchases - <https://apps.apple.com/au/app/dingbats-between-the-lines/id1252269368>
3. Google Play - Rebus Puzzles - Brain Teasers! - <https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.mycompany.rebuspuzzles>
4. Google Play / Apple App Store - Mister Rebus - <https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.okcube.projectr>
5. Apple App Store - Rebus Quest: Word Puzzle Game - <https://apps.apple.com/au/app/rebus-quest-word-puzzle-game/id6759487596>
6. Google Play / Apple App Store - RapidRebus: Word Puzzle Game - <https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.rapidrebus.app>
7. Apple App Store - Riddles, Rebuses and Two Pics - <https://apps.apple.com/au/app/riddles-rebuses-and-two-pics/id1247177252>
8. Apple Developer - App Review and copycats - <https://developer.apple.com/distribute/app-review/>
9. Google Play Developer Policy - Repetitive Content - <https://support.google.com/googleplay/android-developer/answer/17105854>
10. Google Play - Testing requirements for new personal developer accounts - <https://support.google.com/googleplay/android-developer/answer/14151465>
11. Apple Developer - App privacy details and privacy policy requirements - <https://developer.apple.com/app-store/app-privacy-details/>
12. Google Play - Data safety form requirements - <https://support.google.com/googleplay/android-developer/answer/10787469>
13. Apple Developer - Accessibility Nutrition Labels - <https://developer.apple.com/help/app-store-connect/manage-app-accessibility/overview-of-accessibility-nutrition-labels/>

This document is a practical product plan, not legal or financial advice.